COUNTER SALES ESSENTIALS

Counter Sales Essentials — Level 1 — Day 2: Opening and Finding the Real Need

Study guide · Self-study

Level 1 · Day 2: Opening and Finding the Real Need

How to Use This Guide

Welcome to Day 2. Yesterday you mapped the counter sale from start to finish and saw how counter selling differs from other kinds of sales. Today you learn the two skills that decide almost everything that follows: how you open, and how you find out what the customer actually needs.

Read the guide with something to write with. Do every exercise as you reach it, before you read the model answers at the end. The model answers are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

You do not need a counter job to practice today. Every exercise has a no-job-yet option: role-play with a friend, record yourself on your phone, work through a fictional customer given here, or visit a real counter as a customer and watch. If you already work at a counter, you may use your own customers in your head, but never real names, account details or personal data.

Today's ideas appear in this order: the opening, the waiting line, finding the job behind the request, and the number of options you offer. Read one section at a time and practice before moving on.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the four behaviors of the First-Contact Standard, in order, and why each one lowers a customer's guard.

Attitude: You will treat the opening minute as a skill to practice deliberately, not as small talk that happens by accident.

Skill: You will be able to open a counter sale with a customer and a queue waiting, and ask questions that uncover the job behind the request.

Upskill: You will be able to open, acknowledge the queue and ask your first need-finding question inside one calm, unhurried minute, then review your own recording for what to keep and what to drop.

Opening the Sale: The First-Contact Standard

The First-Contact Standard (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Kahneman, Brehm and Guyer et al.) is a four-behavior structure for every first contact, used in this order: Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity. It is a structure, not a script. Its goal is an opening the other person chooses to continue: one that earns attention instead of demanding it.

The order follows the customer's silent questions in the first seconds: Is this safe? Am I free to say no? Is this relevant? Do I want to continue?

Low Threat comes first because a customer walking up to a counter is already slightly on guard. They may be mid-job, in a hurry or unsure they are in the right place. Fast speech, a loud greeting and a rushed "What do you need?" all raise the guard. So you open calmly and unhurried: say who you are and who you represent, at a natural pace. A calm voice and steady pace signal that you are in control and there is no emergency. That answers the first silent question: Is this safe?

Autonomy comes next because people resist being steered. When someone feels pushed, they push back, even against something they wanted a moment earlier. So you give the customer a clear, easy way to decline or say not now. Something like "Take your time, and tell me when you're ready." Feeling free to leave is what makes it safe to stay. That is why an easy exit makes a customer more likely to talk, not less. That answers the second silent question: Am I free to say no?

Relevance answers the third silent question: Is this relevant to me? You give one true, credible reason this contact is about them, not you. At a counter this is often simple. "You're after the fitting for the upstairs job, is that right?" If you have their order or a note from yesterday, use it. One true, specific reason beats a pile of friendly filler, because the customer's fast, automatic judgment is scanning for whether this conversation is worth their time.

Curiosity comes last. You ask one easy, open question that invites them to talk. "What are you working on today?" or "What's the job?" This answers the fourth question, Do I want to continue?, by giving them something easy to say. A customer who starts talking has chosen to stay in the conversation. From that point you are working together, not serving a transaction.

Notice what the order protects you from. Most beginners start with Curiosity, an open question fired at a customer who is still deciding whether to engage. A calm opening, an easy exit and one relevant line make that same question land very differently.

Practice example: A customer walks up to a hardware counter holding a broken hinge. Weak opening: "Hi, what do you need, we're quite busy." Strong opening, in the four behaviors: "Good morning, I'm Sam from the hardware desk." (Low Threat, calm pace) "Take your time, there's no rush." (Autonomy) "You've brought the old hinge, that's the quickest way for us to match it." (Relevance) "What's it going on?" (Curiosity)

The Waiting Line: Why Acknowledgment Matters

On a busy day you will often be serving one customer while two or three more stand waiting. What happens in those minutes decides whether the queue stays calm or turns.

Here is the psychology. A wait that is full of information feels shorter than an empty wait of the same length. A customer who can see what is happening and knows they have been noticed is doing something with their attention. A customer who is ignored has nothing to do but watch the clock and their patience drain. Ignored waiting feels longer, and it feels like disrespect, which is a stronger and longer-lasting feeling than mere delay. That is why the acknowledgment is not a courtesy extra. It is the thing that keeps the line calm. Research on waiting lines found the same: unexplained, unoccupied waits feel longer than explained ones (Maister, 1985).

So acknowledge the queue quickly and honestly. Eye contact, a short line, and something real about the wait. "I've seen you, I'll be with you in a few minutes." Then keep the customer in front of you feeling unhurried. Rushing them to get to the queue makes both customers feel handled badly. Keep your voice steady and your attention on the person at the counter, and let your quick acknowledgment do the work for the people waiting.

If the wait will be long, say so plainly and give the waiting customer a choice. "It's about ten minutes before I can help properly. Would you rather I check something for you now, or would you like to come back at a quieter time?" That is autonomy again, applied to the line.

Practice example: A fictional paint counter, three people waiting. The seller says to the second in line, "I've seen you, I'll be with you shortly. If you already know your color name, I can pull it while I finish this mix." The customer stays calm because they have been seen, given a real estimate and a useful option.

Finding the Job Behind the Request

Most customers name an item. What they have is a job. "I need a two-meter cable" is an item. The job might be connecting a printer across a room, and the cable that fits the job might be a different length or type entirely. Getting the right item the first time starts with asking about the job.

Ask about the job with questions that are easy to answer and tied to what the customer is doing, not to what you want to sell. Good ones are open and concrete:

- "What are you working on?"
- "What's it going on, and what has to fit?"
- "What went wrong with the old one?"
- "When do you need it working by?"

Listen for three things: what the customer is trying to achieve, what constraint they are under (space, time, compatibility, a budget they mention), and what they have already tried. Ask one question at a time and let the answer finish. A customer describing their job is giving you the material to recommend well; a customer answering a checklist of questions feels interrogated.

For regular trade customers you can be faster. They often know exactly what they want and expect you to know their account and their usual items. The job question there is about the job in front of them: "Same as last time, or is this a different job?" One short question respects their time and still catches the case where the job has changed.

Practice example: A customer at an auto parts counter says, "I need a battery." A weak seller hands over the best-selling one. A strong seller asks, "What's it going into, and what's it doing when you turn the key?" The customer says it starts fine in warm weather but clicks on cold mornings. Now the seller knows the job: reliable cold starts, not just any battery.

Why Too Many Options Stall a Sale

Once you know the job, resist the urge to show everything that might work. Offering a long list feels helpful to you and overwhelming to the customer. Most people find it hard to choose between many similar options and end up postponing the decision (Iyengar & Lepper, 2000). A customer facing eight near-identical parts often says "I'll think about it" and leaves, not because none of them fit but because choosing feels risky.

Two or three clear options, explained in the customer's terms, get a decision. You will practice presenting them properly on Day 3. For today, the lesson is in the questions: the better your need-finding, the fewer options you need to offer.

Apply It in Your Role

No-job-yet option: Pick one exercise below and do it today. Role-play with a friend who plays a busy customer, or record yourself on your phone, or use the fictional customer from the section above. Then go to a real counter as a customer, buy something small, and watch how staff open and how they handle the line. Write down two things they did well and one thing you would do differently.

Inside the role: Use the four behaviors in your next three openings. After each one, note in one line which behavior was strongest and which you skipped. Then notice one wait in the queue and how you acknowledged it.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you look at the model answers. Keep them general; do not use real names or details.

1. A customer walks up while you are serving someone and two more are waiting. What do you say, in order?

2. A customer says, "Just give me the cheapest one you have." What is your first question?

3. A customer names an item you are not sure fits their job. What do you ask before you hand it over?

4. You have finished with one customer and the queue has grown. What do you say to the next person?

Key Takeaways

- The First-Contact Standard is four behaviors in order: Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity. It earns attention instead of demanding it.
- Autonomy makes customers more willing to talk, because feeling free to leave is what makes it safe to stay.
- A quick, real acknowledgment keeps a queue calm. Ignored waiting feels longer and feels like disrespect.
- Ask about the job behind the request, not just the item named. That is how you give the right thing the first time.
- Too many options stall a decision. Good need-finding means you only need to offer two or three.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Choose one option for each.

1. What is the correct order of the First-Contact Standard?

A. Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity

B. Curiosity, Relevance, Autonomy, Low Threat

C. Relevance, Curiosity, Low Threat, Autonomy

D. Autonomy, Low Threat, Curiosity, Relevance

2. Why does the standard give the customer an easy way to decline or say not now?

   A. It saves you time if they leave

   B. It shows you are busy

   C. Feeling free to leave makes it safe to stay, so they talk more

   D. It is required before you can quote a price

3. Why does an ignored wait feel longer than an acknowledged one?

   A. Because the customer is timing you

   B. Because time actually passes more slowly

   C. Because customers always complain when waiting

   D. Because a wait with no information or acknowledgment drains patience and feels like disrespect

4. A customer says, "I need a two-meter cable." What should you do first?

   A. Hand over the two-meter cable

   B. Offer every cable you stock

   C. Ask what the cable is for and what has to fit

   D. Tell them the two-meter is out of stock

5. Why do too many options often stop a sale?

   A. Customers rarely buy the first thing they see

   B. Many similar options make choosing feel risky, so the customer postpones

   C. Customers prefer to be told what to buy

   D. More options always mean a higher price

Upskill Challenge

Complete this before your next practice. It has three parts, and each part works with no counter job.

Part 1, the recording: Record a 30-second greeting on your phone using the four behaviors in order, with a friend playing a busy customer. Listen back once and note where your pace sped up.

Part 2, the role-play: Role-play three openings with your friend. In each one, your friend is a different busy customer: one with a broken part, one who says "cheapest one you've got," and one who is silent for a few seconds. Practice staying calm through the silence instead of filling it.

Part 3, the observation: Visit a real counter as a customer and watch one full exchange. Note how the staff member opened, how they acknowledged the line, and one question they asked about the job.

Fill in your review after each part.

Opening I was happiest with: ____

Behavior I skipped most often: ____

One question that found the job: _____

What I will do differently next time: _____

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you; the principle matters more than the exact wording.

1. Opening with a queue. "Good morning, I'm Alex from the parts desk, I'll be right with you." Then to the waiting customer: "I've seen you both, I'll be with you in a few minutes." Why it works: calm pace, a real acknowledgment of the line, and no rushing of the customer in front of you.

2. "Cheapest one you've got." "Happy to find the lowest price that does the job. What are you fitting it to, and what has to work?" Why it works: it respects the budget request and still asks about the job, so you do not sell a part that fails and comes back.

3. Unsure the item fits. "Let's make sure this is the right one before you pay. What's it going on, and how long does it need to last?" Why it works: accuracy beats speed, and the customer hears that you are protecting them, not delaying them.

4. Next in line after a long serve. "Thanks for waiting. I'm with you now. What are you working on today?" Why it works: the acknowledgment comes first, then the curiosity question, so the customer feels seen before they are asked anything.

Quiz answers:

1. A. The order follows the customer's silent questions: safety first, then freedom, then relevance, then the easy open question.

2. C. Autonomy lowers the guard; a customer who can leave without cost is more willing to stay and talk.

3. D. Acknowledgment gives the waiting customer something real to work with, while silence drains patience and feels like disrespect.

4. C. The item is named but the job is not; asking about the job is how you give the right item the first time.

5. B. Many near-identical options make the choice feel risky, so the customer says "I'll think about it" and leaves.

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